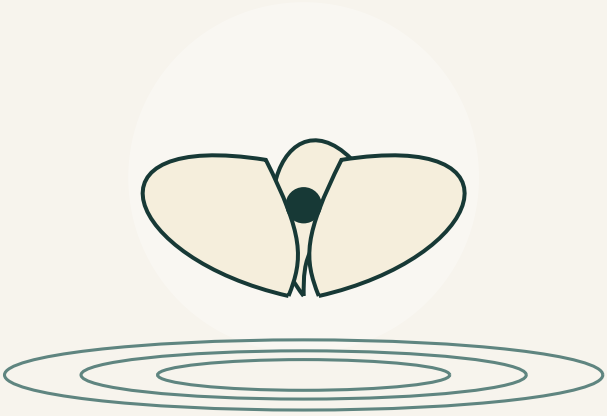
ILLUSTRATED READER'S COMPANION

The Buddhas and Bodhisattvas of the Samādhi Water Repentance

Stories, memorable facts, and pathways through Scrolls One, Two, and Three



A respectful, beginner-friendly guide to every named Buddha and bodhisattva in the English liturgy.

Prepared by Daniel Franjkovic
daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

For all other glossary words: https://www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

Most of the principal figures are introduced in Scroll One and invoked again in Scrolls Two and Three. Dīpaṃkara Buddha appears in the lamp praise that opens Scroll Three. Pronunciations are practical English approximations; they do not reproduce every distinction in Sanskrit, Mandarin or Vietnamese.

Four titles first

Title	Say it like	Meaning
Buddha	*BOOD-uh*	An Awakened One.
Tathāgata	*tuh-THAH-guh-tuh*	“Thus Come One”, a title of a Buddha.
Bodhisattva	*boh-dee-SUT-vuh*	One committed to Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.
Mahāsattva	*muh-HAH-SUT-vuh*	“Great being”, an honorific for an advanced bodhisattva.

Principal Buddhas

Śākyamuni Buddha

Say it like: *SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Sage of the Śākya people **Recognise him:** a monastic Buddha, often touching the earth with his right hand



Śākyamuni is the historical teacher of our world. Born Siddhārtha Gautama in ancient India, he left a privileged life, trained with other seekers, rejected both indulgence and punishing self-denial, awakened beneath the bodhi tree and taught a path out of suffering.

Scroll One calls him “our teacher”. This distinguishes him from the many Buddhas of other ages and worlds invoked in the service.

Why his name is invoked: to take refuge in the teacher who made the path known in this world.

Interesting fact: “Buddha” is a title, not a surname. Śākyamuni is also the seventh of the Seven Ancient Buddhas named in the liturgy.

Practice pathway: see suffering clearly, understand its causes and train in the path that ends them.

Artwork: seventeenth-century Chinese bronze, National Museum in Warsaw. CC0 image via Wikimedia Commons.

Vairocana Buddha

Say it like: *vie-ROH-chah-nah BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Illuminator, or the one who shines throughout **Recognise him:** a central cosmic Buddha, sometimes forming a wisdom-fist hand gesture



Vairocana embodies the Dharma body, awakened reality and wisdom present without limit. He is especially important in the *Flower Adornment Sūtra* world of vast, interpenetrating Buddha-fields.

The universal offerings in Scroll One fit this vision: one flower becomes limitless offerings, and a single act is understood within the whole Dharma realm.

Why his name is invoked: to illuminate hidden motives and place personal reform within a reality larger than the individual.

Interesting fact: Vairocana is often associated with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra. Wisdom and practice reveal the awakened reality he represents.

Practice pathway: bring confusion into the light, then let clear seeing reshape conduct.

Artwork: Vairocana at Longmen Grottoes, China. Mario Biondi, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Amitābha Buddha

Say it like: *ah-mee-TAH-bhah BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Infinite Light **Amitāyus:** *ah-mee-TAH-yoos*, Infinite Life **Recognise him:** seated in meditation or standing to welcome beings, often with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta



Mahāyāna scriptures tell that Amitābha was once the bodhisattva Dharmākara. He made forty-eight vows to establish Sukhāvatī, the Western Pure Land of Ultimate Bliss, as an exceptionally supportive place for awakening.

Scroll One turns towards Amitābha in its dedication and memorial rite. Recollection of his name gathers attention, while aspiration for the Pure Land directs practice towards non-retrogression and liberation.

Why his name is invoked: for mindful recollection, confidence in awakening, care for the deceased and aspiration to favourable conditions for practice.

Interesting fact: Amitābha and Amitāyus are two aspects of the same Buddha, emphasising infinite light and infinite life. “Guide and Receiver of the West” is also Amitābha.

Practice pathway: return a scattered mind to one wholesome direction, then include all beings in the aspiration.

Artwork: ninth-century painting of Amitābha with eight great bodhisattvas. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Medicine Master Buddha

Say it like: *MED-ih-sin MAS-ter BOOD-uh* **Sanskrit:** Bhaiṣajyaguru, approximately *bye-SHAJ-yah-GOO-roo* **Name meaning:** Medicine Teacher **Recognise him:** a Buddha holding a medicine bowl or medicinal plant, often blue in Tibetan art



Medicine Master Buddha made twelve vows concerned with bodily and mental suffering, material need, ethical confusion and conditions supportive of the path. Healing in this tradition is broader than the promise of a cure. It includes wise treatment, relief from fear, ethical reform and a life used well.

Scroll One invokes him during the Noon Offering as “disaster-eradicating and longevity-extending”. This is a traditional devotional title, not a substitute for medical care.

Why his name is invoked: to support healing, protection and the conditions in which wisdom and compassion can grow.

Interesting fact: his full title links healing with lapis-lazuli radiance, a clear blue brilliance associated with purity.

Practice pathway: identify the cause of harm, apply a fitting remedy and use restored strength to help others.

Artwork: Chinese mural of Medicine Master Buddha and his assembly, about 1319, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg).

Dīpaṃkara Buddha

Say it like: *dee-PUNG-kah-rah BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Maker of Light **Recognise him:** an ancient Buddha standing or seated in monastic robes, sometimes connected with lamps



In a famous account, the future Śākyamuni was an ascetic named Sumedha. Seeing muddy ground before Dīpaṃkara, Sumedha spread his hair across it so the Buddha could pass. Dīpaṃkara then predicted that Sumedha would one day become Śākyamuni Buddha.

Scroll Three invokes Dīpaṃkara in the opening lamp praise. The link between his name and light makes him a fitting figure for wisdom illuminating dark paths.

Why his name is invoked: to recall long-term aspiration, humility and confidence that a vow can mature across an immense path.

Interesting fact: the meeting between Dīpaṃkara and Sumedha became a frequent subject in Buddhist art because it represents a future Buddha receiving confirmation of his path.

Practice pathway: make a sincere commitment now, even when its full result lies far beyond the present moment.

Artwork: Nepalese gilt image of Dīpaṃkara, about 1600-1650, Norton Simon Museum. CC0 image via Wikimedia Commons.JPG).

Maitreya

Say it like: *my-TRAY-yah* **Name meaning:** the Loving or Friendly One **Recognise him:** a princely bodhisattva, or in East Asia through the smiling monk Budai



Maitreya is the bodhisattva who will become the next Buddha in this world after Śākyamuni's teaching has disappeared. He is traditionally understood to be teaching in Tuṣita Heaven while awaiting his final birth.

Scroll One calls him “future descending-birth, honoured Maitreya Buddha”, speaking from the perspective of his future awakening.

Why his name is invoked: to cultivate loving-kindness, patience and confidence that the Dharma can appear again in difficult times.

Interesting fact: the familiar round-bellied smiling figure in many East Asian temples is Budai, a Chinese monk later regarded as a manifestation of Maitreya. It is not the only way Maitreya is represented.

Practice pathway: let repentance open a constructive future rather than remain fixed on the past.

Artwork: fifteenth-century painting of Maitreya, Rubin Museum of Art. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Prabhūtaratna Buddha

Say it like: *prah-BOO-tah-RUT-nah BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Many Treasures **Recognise him:** seated beside Śākyamuni inside or above a treasure stūpa



In the *Lotus Sūtra*, Prabhūtaratna's treasure stūpa rises from the earth wherever that teaching is proclaimed. He invites Śākyamuni to sit beside him and bears witness to the teaching.

Scroll One includes both the stūpa and Prabhūtaratna in its Samantabhadra visualisation and Buddha-name litany.

Why his name is invoked: to place the practice before an awakened witness and affirm the continuity of the Dharma.

Interesting fact: East Asian images of two Buddhas seated together usually depict this scene, not two unrelated teachers.

Practice pathway: stop hiding the truth and make reform accountable before a worthy witness.

Artwork: Śākyamuni and Prabhūtaratna, China, dated 609. Gary Todd, CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.jpg).

Principal bodhisattvas

Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva

Say it like: *ah-vah-loh-kee-TAYSH-vah-rah* **Common English or Chinese name:** Guanyin, *gwahn-yin* **Name meaning:** commonly understood in East Asia as the one who observes the cries of the world **Recognise this figure:** a lotus, vase of pure water, willow branch, many arms, or a small Amitābha image in the crown



Avalokiteśvara embodies compassion that hears suffering and responds in whatever form can help. In the *Heart Sūtra* recited during the memorial rite, this bodhisattva also embodies profound wisdom by seeing the five aggregates as empty.

Why the name is invoked: for responsive compassion joined with insight.

Interesting fact: Indian images are often masculine. In China, Vietnam and other parts of East Asia, Guanyin is often represented in a feminine form. These are not separate bodhisattvas.

Practice pathway: listen fully before defending yourself, then respond in a way that actually reduces suffering.

Artwork: Guanyin, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mañjuśrī Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mun-joo-SHREE* **Name meaning:** Wondrous Glory or Wondrous Auspiciousness **Recognise this figure:** a flaming sword, wisdom scripture, lotus or lion mount



Mañjuśrī embodies the wisdom that recognises emptiness and cuts through confused views. In Mahāyāna sūtras he often asks or answers the question that exposes the heart of a teaching.

Why the name is invoked: to understand the conditions behind harmful action and avoid mistaking shame for wisdom.

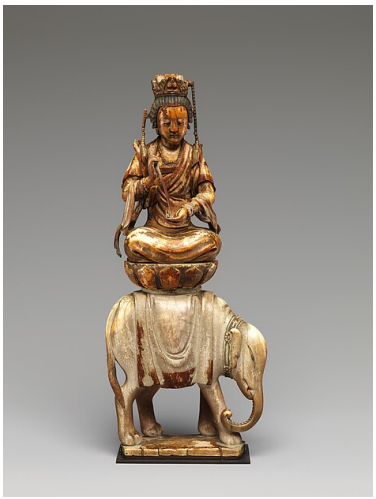
Interesting fact: the sword is not a weapon against people. It represents insight cutting through ignorance. The lion expresses the fearless voice of the Dharma.

Practice pathway: ask which assumption, story or misperception allowed the action to seem reasonable.

Artwork: traditional image of lion-riding Mañjuśrī. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Samantabhadra Bodhisattva

Say it like: *sah-MUN-tah-BHAD-rah* **Name meaning:** Universal Worthy or All-encompassing Good **Recognise this figure:** a white elephant, often with six tusks



Samantabhadra embodies vows carried into practice. His ten great vows include homage, praise, offering, repentance, rejoicing in goodness, requesting the teaching, asking Buddhas to remain, learning, helping beings and dedicating merit.

Scroll One gives him its richest visualisation and invokes him at major transitions.

Why the name is invoked: to turn remorse into sustained compassionate conduct.

Interesting fact: Fo Guang Shan explains the six tusks as the six perfections. The white elephant joins purity with strong, steady movement.

Practice pathway: make the next wholesome action specific enough to perform and repeat.

Artwork: Samantabhadra riding an elephant, China, twelfth to fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāsthāmaprāpta Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mah-HAH-stah-mah-PRAHP-tah* **Name meaning:** Arrival of Great Strength **Recognise this figure:** beside Amitābha, often with a water-vase emblem in the crown



Mahāsthāmaprāpta represents the strength of wisdom, concentration and continuous recollection. Along with Avalokiteśvara, this bodhisattva assists Amitābha in the Western Pure Land.

Why the name is invoked: to gather a scattered mind and sustain wholesome recollection.

Interesting fact: the “great strength” is not domination. It is the power of a mind no longer pulled in every direction.

Practice pathway: choose a wholesome recollection and return to it until it becomes stronger than the old reaction.

Artwork: Mahāsthāmaprāpta, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva

Say it like: *kshih-tee-GAHR-bhah* **Name meaning:** Earth Treasury **Recognise this figure:** a monastic with a staff and wish-fulfilling jewel



Kṣitigarbha is renowned for immense vows to help beings in the hells and other states of severe suffering. The *Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva Sūtra* also connects the practice with gratitude towards parents and care for the deceased.

Why the name is invoked: to extend responsibility and compassion to beings who seem most difficult to reach.

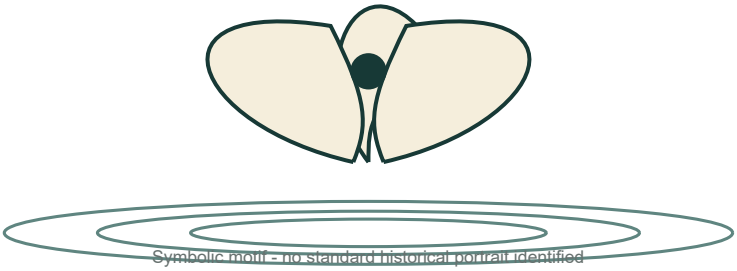
Interesting fact: unlike princely bodhisattvas covered in jewels, Kṣitigarbha often appears as a simple monastic. The image suggests closeness to places of suffering.

Practice pathway: do not abandon the person or situation merely because help will be slow and difficult.

Artwork: Kṣitigarbha, Korea, first half of the fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāvyūha Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mah-HAH-VYOO-hah* **Name meaning:** Great Adornment or Great Array



Scroll One includes Mahāvyūha in its repeated bodhisattva litany but gives no independent story or identifying attributes. “Adornment” in Mahāyāna often means the beauty created by accumulated virtues and compassionate deeds.

No securely standard portrait has been identified for this figure. The symbolic lotus avoids mislabelling a generic image.

Practice pathway: adorn life through conduct rather than appearance alone.

The Seven Ancient Buddhas



Scroll One invokes a traditional succession of seven Buddhas. The first three belong to a previous world age. The final four, ending with Śākyamuni, belong to the present fortunate age. Their recitation places one act of repentance within a long continuity of awakening.

Buddha	Say it like	Note
Vipaśyin	*vih-PUSH-yin*	Often understood as Clear-Seeing.
Śikhin	*SHEE-kin*	A past Buddha, not Śikhin Brahmā.
Viśvabhū	*VISH-vah-BOO*	A Buddha of an earlier world age.
Krakucchanda	*krah-koot-CHUN-dah*	First Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kanakamuni	*kah-nah-kah-MOO-nee*	Second Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kāśyapa Buddha	*KAH-shyah-pah*	Buddha immediately before Śākyamuni, not the disciple Mahākāśyapa.
Śākyamuni	*SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee*	The historical teacher of our world.

Artwork: Chinese sculpture of the Seven Buddhas, Tang to Five Dynasties period. CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.jpg).

Buddhas in the repeated litany

The source names several Buddhas without giving stories or distinctive iconography. Their liturgical purpose is clear: they form an awakened assembly before whom confession and vows are made. The guide does not invent biographies.

Name	Easy pronunciation	Secure beginner note
Nāgagotrodārajñānarāja	*NAH-gah-goh-troh-DAH-rah-NYAH-nah-RAH-jah*	A Buddha whose long title is associated with a noble dragon or nāga lineage and wisdom.
Nāgeśvararāja	*nah-GAYSH-vah-rah-RAH-jah*	“Sovereign King of Nāgas” or “Dragon Sovereign King”.
Buddhapuṇḍarīkadhyaneśvararāja	*BOOD-dhah-poon-dah-REE-kah-DYAH-nay-shvah-rah-RAH-jah*	A title joining the awakening lotus, meditation and sovereign mastery.
Kasayadhvaja	*kah-SAH-yah-dvah-jah*	“Banner of the monastic robe”, an image of renunciation and the Dharma made visible.
Siṃhanāda	*SING-hah-NAH-dah*	“Lion's Roar”, an image of fearless Dharma teaching.

Ritual and collective invocations

Some titles sound like individual people but function more naturally as invocations of an image, quality or assembly.

Invocation	Meaning in context
Incense Cloud Canopy Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	The fragrant offering imagined as a vast canopy reaching awakened assemblies.
Precious Uḍumbara Blossom Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	An auspicious blossom famous in Buddhist literature for rarity, used here in an offering and homage context. No secure individual biography is supplied.
Equal Awakening Stage Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	Advanced bodhisattvas at the stage immediately preceding complete Buddhahood.
Pure Cool Ground Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A memorial invocation of purity and relief from the “heat” of affliction.
Dhyāna Bliss Treasury Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A personified image of the deep joy and ease associated with meditation.
Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas	Protectors of monasteries and Buddhist practice places.